THE COMEBACK



Former IAS officer **Sujata Rout Karthikeyan's** entry into the Biju Janata Dal (BJD) is more than a routine induction, say sources, notwithstanding party supremo and ex-CM Naveen Patnaik's claim that she would be "a simple member". Sujata is the wife of V.K. Pandian, the former bureaucrat-turned-politician widely blamed by BJD insiders for the party's 2024 poll debacle. She had taken voluntary retirement in 2025, but now Odisha's power couple seems to be coming back centre stage in the BJD.

SPEAKER'S BLOCK



Maharashtra assembly speaker **Rahul Narwekar** recently got into a soup with his stumbling Marathi while reading out the obituary reference for the late iconic singer Asha Bhosle. Though the BJP leader and Colaba MLA apologised for the gaffe, it has triggered a hot debate in some quarters: the state government wants taxi and rickshaw drivers to learn Marathi, so shouldn't elected representatives at least be expected to converse well in the language?

TRUST DEFICIT



Madhya Pradesh urban development minister **Kailash Vijayvargiya** recently dropped a bomb about the state's bureaucracy. The BJP leader claimed that over the past two decades when the party was in power in the state (with a brief Congress interlude), he had met several officers who, seeking to curry favour with the regime, made false claims about being "close" to the Sangh. Analysts say the remark, made at a Sangh event in Bhopal, suggests the BJP is still unconvinced about the bureaucracy's 'commitment' to the party's cause.

Kaushik Deka *with* Ashish Misra, Arkamoy Datta Majumdar, Dhaval S. Kulkarni *and* Rahul Noronha

HEALTH WATCH

SLEEP TRACKERS
BOON OR BANE

By **Sonali Acharjee**

For many young professionals, the first thing they check in the morning is no longer the time—it is the sleep score on their smart watches. The shift reflects a growing awareness that sleep is as important to health as diet and exercise. People now want to know how well they slept and wearables promise to answer that question by tracking everything, from deep sleep and REM sleep to resting heart rate, blood oxygen levels, heart rate variability (HRV) and recovery or "readiness" scores.



Experts say the technology has encouraged many people to take sleep seriously for the first time. The information can also motivate healthier habits, such as sticking to a bedtime, reducing late-night screen time or cutting back on caffeine. But there is another trend emerging alongside it. Instead of helping people sleep better, the data is making some worry more about sleep. Many users now obsess over increasing their deep sleep or understanding why their readiness score is dropping.

Experts caution that consumer wearables are useful for identifying broad trends, but they are not medical devices. Sleep stages are estimates based on movement, heart rate and other signals, and should not be treated as precise measurements. Researchers have even coined a term for this phenomenon: orthosomnia—the unhealthy pursuit of perfect sleep driven by wearable data. Ironically, worrying excessively about getting a good night's sleep can itself make it harder to fall asleep. But this does not mean people should stop using sleep trackers. Experts say they can be most useful when viewed as long-term guides rather than daily report cards.